VEHICLE EMERGENCY PREP

A car ready to evacuate, a kit for breakdowns and winter, and what to do if you're stranded.

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GUIDE / VERIFY: General preparedness information, not a substitute for professional training, local rules, manufacturer instructions or medical care. **Practice skills in safe conditions before you need them, and verify important information with current official sources.**

1. KEEP THE CAR READY

- ☐ Keep the gas tank **at least half full**, especially in winter and in storm season. Gas stations need power to pump.
- ☐ Electric vehicles: keep a good charge when storms are forecast; cold weather cuts range. Know your charging stops on evacuation routes.
- ☐ Tires: correct pressure (the sticker inside the driver's door) and enough tread. Check the spare.
- ☐ Battery: most last 3 to 5 years. Have it tested before winter.
- ☐ Wipers, washer fluid, lights, coolant / antifreeze, oil.
- ☐ Check for safety recalls by VIN at nhtsa.gov/recalls.
- ☐ Know two routes out of your area, and keep a paper map in the car. *(TR-04)*

2. CAR EMERGENCY KIT

ALL YEAR

- ☐ Jumper cables or a jump-starter pack
- ☐ Flashlight and extra batteries
- ☐ First-aid kit *(TR-05)*
- ☐ Water and non-perishable snacks
- ☐ Phone charger and cable; a charged power bank
- ☐ Reflective warning triangles or road flares; a reflective vest
- ☐ Basic tools; duct tape; work gloves
- ☐ Tire inflator or sealant, and a tire pressure gauge
- ☐ Paper maps
- ☐ Rain jacket; sturdy walking shoes
- ☐ Copy of your Emergency Contact Sheet *(DC-01)*

ADD FOR WINTER

- ☐ Blankets or sleeping bags
- ☐ Hats, gloves, warm coats, extra socks
- ☐ Ice scraper and snow brush
- ☐ Small shovel
- ☐ Sand or cat litter for traction
- ☐ Hand warmers
- ☐ Brightly colored cloth to tie to the antenna

ADD FOR HEAT

- ☐ Extra water
- ☐ Sun shade for the windshield; hat; sunscreen

3. WHEN SOMETHING GOES WRONG

SITUATION	WHAT TO DO
Breakdown	Signal and pull as far off the road as you can. Hazard lights on. Set out triangles behind the car if it's safe. If you're stuck in a traffic lane or on a narrow shoulder, staying buckled in may be safer than standing near traffic. Call for help.

Flooded road	**Turn around, don't drown.** 12 inches of moving water can carry away most cars. If water rises around the car, get out and to higher ground if you can do so safely.
Stranded in snow	**Stay with the car.** Run the engine about 10 minutes an hour for heat, with a window cracked, and keep the exhaust pipe clear of snow. Dome light on while the engine runs. Move to keep warm; take turns sleeping. *(TR-03)*
Downed power line	Stay in the car and call 911. If you must get out because of fire, jump clear without touching the car and the ground at the same time, then shuffle away with small steps.
Wildfire smoke on the road	Headlights on, slow down, windows and vents closed, air on recirculate. Follow official routes.

(!) **NEVER LEAVE A CHILD OR PET IN A PARKED CAR,** even for a minute, even with the windows down. On a warm day the inside can heat up about 20°F in 10 minutes. And never run the engine in a closed garage.

4. VEHICLE RECORD

Vehicle (year / make / model / color)	
License plate / VIN	
Insurance company / policy number	
Roadside assistance number	
Tire pressure (front / rear)	
Battery installed (date)	
Kit last checked (date)	

SOURCES / FURTHER REFERENCE

1. FEMA: Ready.gov: Car Safety; Winter Weather; Evacuation. `ready.gov/car`
2. National Highway Traffic Safety Administration: Winter Driving Tips; Heatstroke; Recalls; Tire Safety. `nhtsa.gov`
3. National Weather Service: Turn Around Don't Drown; Winter Travel Safety. `weather.gov/safety`

IMPORTANT: Follow your vehicle owner's manual and local traffic laws. This document reflects the sources above as of November 2026.